



SAT JAN 31 8PM
SANDERS THEATRE

RUCKUS AND DAVÓNE TINES

WHAT IS YOUR HAND IN THIS?

PART I

Beautiful Dreamer	Stephen Foster
Overture from <i>Compassion Preludes</i>	Douglas Adam August Balliett
The Four F's from <i>Compassion Preludes</i>	Balliett
Be the Lover of My Soul	Traditional / arr. Davóne Tines

PART II

Concerto Grosso No. 10 in D minor, Op. 6: ii	George Frederic Handel
Scherzo from <i>Compassion Preludes</i>	Balliett
The Liberty Song	John Dickinson / arr. Balliett
Concerto Grosso No. 10 in D minor, Op. 6: iv	Handel
What Mean Ye?	George W. Clark

PART III

A New Death March	Sawney Freeman
To the White People of America	Joshua McCarter Simpson
The Rays of Liberty	Freeman
Federal Nations	Balliett
The Federal Overture	Benjamin Carr
"Why do the Nations so Furiously Rage"	Handel
from <i>Messiah</i>	
The House I Live In	Allan & Robinson / arr. Tines & Balliett

PART IV

Buddha	Julius Eastman
This Bitter Earth	Clyde Otis arr. Tines & Balliett
What is My Hand in This?	Tines, arr. Balliett
Chester	William Billings / arr. Balliett
A Change is Gonna Come	Sam Cooke
Nunc Dimittis from <i>Compassion Preludes</i>	Balliett
Be the Lover of My Soul (Reprise)	Traditional / arr. Tines

There will be no intermission in this evening's program, which will run approximately one hour and 15 minutes.

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THE PERFORMERS AND THE WORK

Ruckus

Douglas Adam August Balliett electric bass, arrangements and compositions

Elliot Figg harpsichord, piano, electric keyboard

Keir GoGwilt violin

Manami Mizumoto viola

Paul Holmes Morton baroque guitar

Shelby Yamin violin

Clay Zeller-Townson baroque bassoon, taille, percussion, research

Davóne Tines singer and arrangements

Harvard-Radcliffe Collegium Musicum, Dr. Hana Cai, conductor

Program conceived by Douglas Balliett, Davóne Tines and Clay Zeller-Townson.

Developed by Ruckus Early Music.

Commissioned by Carnegie Hall and Hudson Hall with support from the New York State Council of the Arts.

WHAT IS YOUR HAND IN THIS?

America's music at the founding of the country
was the music of dissent.

We celebrate this tradition.

Ruckus and Davóne Tines

NOTES ON MUSICAL SOURCES & SONG TEXTS

Beautiful Dreamer (1864)

Words and music by Stephen Foster (1826-1864)

One of Stephen Foster's most iconic parlor songs, "Beautiful Dreamer" was one of the final songs he wrote while in bad health and in desperate need of money. Its sentimental style is devoid of the minstrel themes that many of his songs contained. It has become one of his most performed songs in the last century, covered by The Beatles, Roy Orbison, Bing Crosby, and many others.

Beautiful Dreamer, wake unto me,
Starlight and dewdrops are waiting for thee;
Sounds of the rude world heard in the day,
Lull'd by the moonlight have all pass'd away!

Beautiful dreamer, queen of my song,
List while I woo thee with soft melody;
Gone are the cares of life's busy throng
Beautiful dreamer, awake unto me!
Beautiful dreamer, awake unto me!

Overture and The Four Fs from Compassion Preludes (2025)

Doug Balliett (b. 1982)

Commissioned for the occasion, works from the *Compassion Preludes* were created for this program and interspersed throughout. The Overture is instrumental; the texts of the Four Fs follows:

Evolutionary biologists are all agreed:
that there are four basic needs,
That every animal feels
Though some will say the drive
Is all from the genes.
And these needs can be destructive
When they when they collide with privilege and power
But we live with these needs
They're called the Four F's:
We fight, We flee, we feed, and we F*ind a way to keep reproducing
And these truths are self-evident,
that we are plagued by fear ...of one another
...and want... of more...
and desire... for acceptance.
But America has always left somebody out.
And we don't know how to make America...

Be the Lover of My Soul

Traditional, as sung by Providence Baptist Church, Orlean, Virginia
Arranged by Davóne Tines (b. 1986)

Davóne Tines grew up singing this hymn (as “Jesus, Lover of My Soul”) at the Providence Baptist Church of Orlean, VA. He has adapted it and arranged it for this program.

Be the lover of my soul,
let me to thy bosom fly,
while the nearer waters roll,
while the tempest still is high;

Hide me, O my Savior, hide,
till the storm of life is past;
safe into the haven guide,
O receive my soul at last!

Liberty Song (1768/2025)

Lyrics: John Dickinson (1732-1808)

Tune: “Heart of Oak”

Arrangement: Douglas Balliett (b. 1982)

When John Dickinson published his “Letters from a Pennsylvania Farmer” in 1767-1768, he became a political celebrity across the colonies. While they were written to protest the Townsend Acts, Dickinson’s goal was novel: he taught citizens how to begin to think of themselves as a united “American” people, rather than British subjects divided across the sea. Shortly after these letters were published, Dickinson penned “The Liberty Song,” to further this notion musically. In its chorus, Dickinson repeats over and over the founding hypocrisy of the American Revolution: “not as slaves, but as freemen our money we’ll give.” Indeed, while Dickinson wrote “The Liberty Song” he had dozens of enslaved people working on his farm in Delaware. The song became one of the most popular songs of the time, and was sung to the well-known tune (and anthem of the British Royal Navy) “Heart of Oak.”

Come, join hand in hand, brave Americans all,
And rouse your bold hearts at fair Liberty’s call;
No tyrannous acts shall suppress your just claim,
Or stain with dishonor America’s name.

Chorus:

In Freedom we’re born and in Freedom we’ll live.

Our purses are ready. Steady, friends, steady;

Not as slaves, but as Freemen our money we’ll give.

Our worthy forefathers, let's give them a cheer,
To climates unknown did courageously steer;
Threw' oceans to deserts for Freedom they came,
And dying, bequeath'd us their freedom and fame

Chorus

How sweet are the labors that free men endure,
that men shall enjoy the sweet profit secure.
No more sweet labors Americans know,
If British shall reap what Americans sow.

Chorus

What Mean Ye? (1845)

Published in *The Liberty Minstrel*

Lyrics: George W. Clark (dates unknown)

Hymn: "Mear" (composer unknown) as appears in *The Sacred Harp*

The *Liberty Minstrel*, just as in Joshua McCarter Simpson's *Emancipation Car*, functioned as a way for abolitionists to express themselves during group meetings. Abolitionist George Washington Clark published numerous songbooks in his lifetime for the cause. "What Mean Ye?" has an everlasting power, as it simply sets forth a series of searing questions to the listener. The chorale we have set it to, "Mear," has been a favorite of shape-note singers (a living tradition of American folk singing) for hundreds of years, and is one of the oldest hymns found in *The Sacred Harp*.

What mean ye that ye bruise and bind
My people, saith the Lord,
And starve your craving brother's mind,
That asks to hear my word?

What mean ye that ye make them toil
Through long and dreary years,
And shed like rain upon your soil
Their blood and bitter tears?

What mean ye that ye dare to rend
The tender mother's heart;
Brothers from sisters, friend from friend,
How dare you bid them part?

What mean ye, when God's bounteous hand
To you so much has given,
That from all those who till your land
You keep both earth and heaven?

When at the judgement God shall call,
Where is thy brother? say,
What mean ye to the Judge of all,
To answer on that day?

A New Death March & The Rays of Liberty (1801?)
by Sawney Freeman (1769-1828)

Sawney Freeman's music has only very recently been rediscovered. Born into slavery in Connecticut around 1770, he escaped in 1790. Freeman was a devoted violin player and composer, and he is one of the earliest known published Black American composers, writing in the New England four-part instrumental-chorale idiom. His "New Death March" is likely written in reaction to Handel's March from *Saul*, a perennial piece that made its way into many of these "instrumental tutor" publications of the time. Freeman's first known publication was his *Musicians Pocket Companion* of 1801 (an existing copy has yet to be found). The works in this program were collected in the "Gurdon Trumbull Copybook" from 1817.

To the White People of America (1854)
Published in *The Emancipation Car*
by Joshua McCarter Simpson (ca. 1820-1877)
Tune: "Massa's in the Cold Cold Ground," 1852

In 2022 a new resource became available to students of American musical history. *Songs of Slavery and Emancipation*, a collection of some of the earliest published songs from the Black American experience was compiled and published by Mat Callahan and the University Press of Mississippi. In this collection we found the work of Joshua McCarter Simpson and his *Emancipation Car*. Simpson's boldly honest preface ("A Note to the Public") and his searing texts were among the earliest findings that felt essential for us as performers. "To The White People of America" holds a powerful balance of ideas: calling out the hypocrisy of white enslavers, questioning if anyone can actually hear his people's suffering, and a remarkable refrain: "the day will come that you must die." Is this a condemnation, is it speaking a truth that we are all equal under the force of mortality? Or is he referring to the death of an ideology? Simpson carefully chose the tune to set this text to: Stephen Foster's "Massa's in the Cold Cold Ground," a song often sung in minstrel shows portraying an enslaved person as lamenting the death of his enslaver.

O'er this wide extended country,
Hear the solemn echoes roll,
For a long and weary century,
Those cries have gone from pole to pole;

See the white man sway his sceptre,
In one hand he holds the rod—
In the other hand the Scripture,

And says that he's a man of God.
Hear ye that mourning? 'Tis your brothers' cry!
O! ye wicked men take warning,
The day will come when you must die.

Lo! Ten thousand steeples shining
Through this mighty Christian land,
While four millions slaves all pining
And dying 'neath the Tyrant's hand.

See the "blood-stained" Christian banner
Followed by a host of saints
While they loudly sing Hosannah,
We hear the dying slave's complaints:

Hear ye that mourning? Anglo-sons of God,
O! ye Hypocrites take warning,
And shun your sable brothers blood.

Federal Nations (2025)

by Douglas Balliett, using:

"Why do the Nations so Furiously Rage" from *Messiah* (1741) by Handel
(1685-1759); *The Federal Overture* (1794) by Benjamin Carr (1768-1831)

"Federal Nations" combines two works of 18th-century music: Handel's rage aria from *Messiah* and Benjamin Carr's concert overture celebrating the birth of the Republic. Composer Douglas Balliett weaves both together to form an unhinged, madcap ride of rage and pomp. Carr's "Federal Overture" has all the elements you'd expect from one of the earliest uniquely American symphonic works: a yankee doodle fugue, folk song arrangements, and late classical "sturm und drang."

Why do the nations so furiously rage together:
why do the people imagine a vain thing?

The kings of the earth rise up,
and the rulers take counsel together:
against the Lord and His anointed.

The House I Live In (1942/2025)

Music: Earl Robinson (1910-1991)

Lyrics: Abel Meeropol (aka Lewis Allan; 1903-1986)

Arr. Tines / Balliett

"The House I Live In" first appeared in a Broadway revue called *Let Freedom Ring!* in 1942, but was made an instant classic in 1945 when sung by Frank Sinatra in a short film of the same name. The film was created to oppose anti-Semitism in

the post-war moment, but the song has been covered by many artists as a way of broadening the language of who should be considered an American. The second and third verses in this program were written by Davóne Tines, and this version appears on his album *ROBESON*.

The house I live in, the friends that I have found,
The folks beyond the railroad and the people all around,
The worker and the farmer, the sailor on the sea,
The folks who built this country, that's America to me.

But we know this country will always have its way
With people sleeping soundly, while their rotting dreams decay
It lays it trap full willing to justify the killing
While wracking up the billing on a debt to never pay

While truth becomes banished and justice never won
Our hopes to find some freedom, still just raisins in the sun
It's sad to see it failing, its the way its always been
To never cleanse the staining of its bloody primal sin

Cause that's America,
What's America?
Who's America?
Where's America?

Find America... for me

Buddha (1984)

Music: Julius Eastman (1940-1990)

Julius Eastman has become an American icon of radical minimalism whose music is finally getting the platform it deserves. "Buddha" is presented to performers as a graphic score—a series of musical lines, mostly long tones, housed within a large oval (Is it an egg? The belly of The Buddha?). Any performer may take any line and react to the musical moment—creating a sustained and tense sonic meditation.

This Bitter Earth (1960)

Music and lyrics: Clyde Otis (1924-2008)

Arrangement: Davóne Tines and Douglas Balliett

"This Bitter Earth" was popularized by Dinah Washington and was one of her final hits in her lifetime, rising to #1 on the Billboard Hot R&B charts.

This bitter earth
Well, what a fruit it bears
What good is love

That no one shares?
And if my life is like the dust
That hides the glow of a rose
What good am I?
Heaven only knows

Oh, this bitter earth
Yes, can it be so cold?
Today you're young
Too soon you're old
But while a voice
Within me cries
I'm sure someone
May answer my call
And this bitter earth,
May not, be so bitter after all

What is My Hand in This? (2025)

Words and music by Davóne Tines (b. 1986)

The idea for the song "What is My Hand in This" came from an invitation to be part of the entertainment at a Christmas party in one of New York City's wealthiest neighborhoods. Davóne took this as an opportunity not to entertain, but to speak directly and imploringly to a room of the 1% with the subtext "You in this room have the power to affect great change, so what is your hand in contributing?" The tune borrows from Black American folk tradition.

What is my hand in this?
As you go about your day,
Do you ever stop and say,
What is my hand in this?

What is my hand in this?
As you fret upon your woes
And cast the blame upon your foes, please ask
What is my hand in this?

What is my hand in this?
While you listen to this song,
Will you try to right your wrong, asking,
What is my hand in this?

Chester (1778)

Words and music by William Billings (1746-1800)

Published in *The Singing Master's Assistant*

Arrangement: Douglas Balliett (b. 1982)

“Chester” has always been an anthem of the American Revolution, functioning in its day as a way for New Englanders to demonstrate solidarity and to cry out together during a tumultuous and war-ravaged time. “Chester” existed in many forms, as a tune to be roared out or played in the streets, or as a four-part hymn to be sung in meeting houses, singing schools, and churches.

What grateful Off’ring shall we bring?
What shall we render to the World?
Loud Halleluiahs let us Sing,
And praise the name on ev’ry Chord.

A Change is Gonna Come (1964)

Sam Cooke (1931-1964), arr. Balliett

I was born by the river
In a little tent
Oh, and just like the river, I’ve been running
Ever since
It’s been a long
A long time coming, but I know
A change gon’ come
Oh yes, it will

It’s been too hard living
But I’m afraid to die
‘Cause I don’t know what’s up there
Beyond the sky
It’s been a long
A long time coming, but I know
A change gon’ come
Oh yes, it will

I go to the movie
And I go downtown
And somebody keep telling me
“Don’t hang around”
It’s been a long
A long time coming, but I know
A change gon’ come
Oh yes, it will

Then, I go to my brother
And I say, "Brother, help me, please"
But he winds up knockin' me
Back down on my knees, oh

There been times that I thought
I couldn't last for long
But now, I think I'm able
To carry on
It's been a long
A long time coming, but I know
A change gon' come
Oh yes, it will

"Nunc Dimittis" from *Compassion Preludes* (2025)

Douglas Balliett (b. 1982)

The fifth of the *Compassion Preludes* of Douglas Balliet performed today, this is one of two with a vocal part.

We will finally be in peace
When the promise is fulfilled
My eyes will see the glory
Of the coming of the day
When a light will reveal to the nation
The error of his ways.
Glory to the Father and to the Son
And the Mother and the Daughter and actually
To everyone
What could have been in the beginning is beginning now,
What will be your hand in this?

Notes by Clay Zeller-Townson

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